Manmohan Samal and minister Suresh Pujari say the government isn't scared of a no-trust vote. Pujari even dared the Opposition to "bring it on". Deputy CM Pravati Parida also highlighted how cases were promptly registered and investigated, something she claimed did not happen under the BJD's watch.

Even if the debate is lively, the numbers would ground any Opposition flight of fancy. The ruling alliance has a comfortable majority of 81 seats: 78 BJP MLAs plus three Independents. The BJD and the Congress, pooled, muster only 65—well short of critical mass. Hence, the move would lack any material benefit. What can be gained is only symbolic. So is what can be lost.

Takeaways

- **The Odisha Congress has dared the BJD to move a no-confidence motion**
- **Agreeing means being led by old rival Congress. Evading would be pro-BJP**
- **Strategic ambiguity has been useful till now, but now BJD has to choose a side**

On the upcoming vice-presidential election, too, the party is treading the same ambivalent ground it occupied during the Waqf Bill vote, where no whip was issued, and 'vote by conscience' was allowed. That episode triggered internal rumblings and external criticism, complicating the BJD's already enfeebled image of regional autonomy. The spur in its side now is a resurgent Congress under Das, positioning itself as the "real Opposition" through statewide bandhs and vocal assembly theatrics. Under such circumstances, how far can strategic inertia last? ■

▶ UTTAR PRADESH

THE GODS OF S

Call them the political version of MSMEs—micro, small and medium-sized enterprises crucial to the BJP's gameplan in UP. Why are they suddenly restive?

By **Avaneesh Mishra**

In Uttar Pradesh, the smallest players always punch above their weight—and often land the meatier cuts. It's a function of the high-value political real estate market they operate in. So why are the tiny NDA allies who make up the BJP's retinue suddenly acting up? Well, panchayat elections are due next year and the crucial assembly polls follow in 2027. So, they can smell good meat, and piqued appetites have got them all restless. The Apna Dal(S) has begun airing its grievances in public. The Nirbal Indian Shoshit Hamara Aam Dal (NISHAD) party is threatening to walk out if its demand for SC status for fisherfolk is not met. The Suheldev Bharatiya Samaj Party (SBSP), which has made fickleness its calling card, has turned up the volume on increasing the OBC quota share for Rajbhars. These parties have historically stayed afloat and thrived by sensing which way the wind is blowing—shifting sides is an innate skill, a tradition. With the BJP facing a two-term anti-incumbency and the Samajwadi Party out shopping for affections, these allies know their bargaining power is at its peak. Where they choose to go could redraw the political map of India's most consequential state.

NISHAD PARTY

Sanjay Nishad, President



Sanjay Nishad, UP's fisheries minister, warns that his party might reconsider its support in 2027 unless the BJP delivers on its promise of Scheduled Caste (SC) status to OBC fisherfolk. The intent was made clear with a bold hoarding outside Nishad's Lucknow home. He has reasons to worry—the SP's

"The BJP has found solutions to all difficult issues. So what's keeping it from fulfilling its promise to the fisherfolk?"

ship had loomed large on its waters in the 2024 Lok Sabha election.

Founded in 2016, NISHAD represents 22 riverine sub-castes that make up 12-18 per cent of UP's OBC population. Concentrated in eastern and central UP where the Ganga and Yamuna crash the banks, they have a say in 160-odd assembly seats, making them crucial to the BJP's plans. NISHAD feels ill-compensated for what it brings to the table—a couple of dry bypolls even led to a statewide show of strength. Legal hurdles make the SC status demand hard to fulfil, but the BJP will be wary of fishing lines on the opposite bank.